

DTC's Inclusive Lifelong Multistakeholder Model

1) Core Framework

Fundamental Principles and Key Objectives

The inclusive lifelong multistakeholder model is built on the belief that governance is strongest when it captures the full arc of human experience. Its key objectives are:

- To ensure every stage of life has a defined, easily understood, and legitimate role in governance processes.
- To make participation continuous so no stage feels like a reset or reinvention.
- To embed mentoring and reciprocal learning as part of the culture, not just an add-on.
- To safeguard participants through legal, ethical, and procedural standards at every stage.
- To strengthen governance outcomes by combining emerging perspectives with historical insight.

Stakeholder Roles and Engagement Mechanisms

Children (0–12)

Children engage through developmentally appropriate participation zones designed to feel safe, creative, and connected to real governance themes. Drawing inspiration from the Children's IGF led by the Wototo Watch Network in Kenya and the environments pioneered by Jutta Croll's Stiftung Digitale Chancen in Germany, these spaces use storytelling, art, and play to surface children's views. Trained facilitators act as translators, carrying these insights into multistakeholder discussions without losing their authenticity. Each child's contributions are potentially added to a longitudinal record so their perspectives evolve into the governance narrative as they grow.

Teens (13–19)

This is the formal gateway into governance as a full digital actor. Participation happens in moderated, safeguarded environments where teens co-create projects, propose policy ideas, and join deliberations as equals. Teens move fluidly between peer-led collaboration and formal decision-making spaces, with structured pathways toward early career roles. Mentorship flows in both directions. Teens learn from older peers and professionals, and also mentor children entering the system, strengthening their own confidence and leadership skills.

Early Career (18+)

Here, participants consolidate governance literacy, policy fluency, and strategic leadership skills. They take on facilitation and mentoring roles for teens, serve as rapporteurs in multistakeholder groups, and begin to shape agendas. This stage acts as the capacity-building engine of the model, producing confident leaders who understand both the technical and relational aspects of governance.

Mid Career

Mid-career participants operate at the intersection of vision and execution. They set priorities, resolve conflicts, and broker cross-sector collaborations. They are the stewards of institutional culture, ensuring the values of inclusivity and mentorship remain embedded as the model scales.

Senior Career

Seniors bring historic perspective, institutional memory, and ethical oversight. They act as guardians of the governance record and facilitators of intergenerational dialogue, making sure that lessons learned are accessible to future decision-makers. Their presence anchors innovation in context, ensuring continuity without stifling new approaches.

2) Operational Model

Implementation Procedures and Governance Structure

- Define rights, responsibilities, and safeguards for each stage in governance charters.
- Maintain stage-specific participation spaces (both physical and digital) with appropriate moderation and facilitation.
- Embed cross-stage working groups into existing structures so collaboration happens by design, not chance.

- Use transition protocols to move participants between stages without loss of role or influence.
- Build a longitudinal participation archive that tracks individual and collective contributions over time.

Required Resources and Capacity Building Needs

- Trained facilitators and moderators experienced in child and teen participation.
- Digital platforms providing full community asynchronous work spaces, microlearning/microcerts, with built-in safeguarding, accessibility, and multilingual support.
- Age-tailored capacity-building programs covering governance literacy, negotiation, policy development, and facilitation.
- Sustainable funding to ensure equitable participation, including connectivity and accessibility support.

3) Impact Analysis

Global Implications

- Establishes an international precedent for age-inclusive governance.
- Strengthens global cooperation by creating a shared, scalable framework.
- Provides a portable standard that can be adopted by other multistakeholder bodies.

Local/National Effects

- Encourages governments to adopt intergenerational participation models domestically.
- Brings fresh perspectives to local decision-making while reinforcing democratic legitimacy.

Comparative Advantages over Current Systems

- Closes participation gaps caused by age restrictions.
- Maintains continuity and institutional memory across governance cycles.
- Creates a resilient structure adaptable to diverse cultural and political contexts.
- Defines and embeds legal and ethical supports for all stages, ensuring rights, safeguarding, and accountability are integral from the outset.
- Builds genuine intergenerational collaboration into governance culture, rather than treating it as outreach.
- Stages are self-selecting wherever possible, allowing participants to enter the level that best reflects their skills, responsibilities, and goals rather than simply their chronological age.
- Recognizes that a participant in mid-life could still be in an early career stage, such as a mature-age graduate or career shifter, shifting the purpose of their engagement toward capacity building and integration rather than advancement from youth.

4) Transition Strategy

Phased Implementation Approach

1. Mapping and alignment: Review existing participation models and identify integration points.
2. Pilot phase: Implement in one or more governance spaces with full age-stage representation.
3. Scaling: Expand to additional processes, guided by evaluation and feedback.
4. Institutionalization: Embed in governance charters, operational procedures, and training frameworks.

Risk Assessment and Mitigation Plans

Resistance to change → Use pilot evidence and stakeholder champions to build support.

Safeguarding concerns → Apply best-practice frameworks with independent oversight.

Resource constraints → Leverage partnerships, in-kind support, and phased budgeting.

Success Metrics and Evaluation Criteria

- Representation of all age stages in governance bodies.
- Retention and progression rates across stages.
- Evidence of intergenerational collaboration influencing policy outcomes.
- Adoption of the model by international, regional, and national institutions.

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